

Jeremiah 10 - 12

Key Notes, Cross-References, and Messianic Connections (WEB)

Tonight the contrast is drawn as sharply as it will ever be drawn - between gods that have to be nailed down so they don't fall over, and the God whose voice makes the waters roar.

A tree cut from the forest, plated in silver, carried on a shoulder because it cannot walk.

A covenant read aloud in the streets with a curse attached, and a prophet who answers, "Amen, Yahweh."

A man who discovers that the people plotting his death are his own neighbors, from his own hometown.

Jeremiah 10 sets the idols of the nations beside the living God and lets the comparison do the work - ending, unexpectedly, in one of the humblest prayers in the book: correct me, but gently.

Jeremiah 11 puts the covenant back on the table with its curse intact, and then reveals a conspiracy - not against Yahweh in the abstract, but against the man carrying His words, hatched in Anathoth among people who had known him since childhood.

Jeremiah 12 is where he finally says it out loud. Why do the wicked prosper? And Yahweh's answer is not an explanation. It is a question about horses.

This is not just history.

This is a mirror.

And tonight, we let the Word fill us.

CHAPTER 10 - Gods That Must Be Carried, and a God Who Carries

Key Notes

- The opening command is about formation, not just behavior: don't learn the way of the nations, and don't be dismayed at the signs of the sky. Fear is the thing being imported (Jeremiah 10:1-2).
- The manufacture of an idol is described step by step, deliberately deflating: a tree is cut, worked with an ax, plated with silver and gold, then fastened with nails and hammers so that it cannot fall over (Jeremiah 10:3-4).
- The verdict of verse 5 is almost gentle. They cannot speak. They must be carried. Don't be afraid of them - they can't do harm, and doing good is not in them either. Powerlessness in both directions (Jeremiah 10:5).
- Against that, a hymn erupts: there is no one like You, Yahweh. Great in might, King of the nations, and no one among all the wise men of the nations compares (Jeremiah 10:6-7).
- Verse 10 stacks the titles that answer everything preceding: the true God, the living God, an everlasting King. Idols are none of the three (Jeremiah 10:10).
- The single Aramaic verse in the chapter is a line Judah could hand to their neighbors: gods who did not make heaven and earth will perish from under them (Jeremiah 10:11).
- Creation is offered as proof of authority - earth by His power, world by His wisdom, heavens stretched out by His understanding, and weather that answers His voice (Jeremiah 10:12-13).
- "The portion of Jacob is not like these" - the difference is not that Israel's God is a better idol, but that He is the Maker and they are His inheritance (Jeremiah 10:16).
- The shepherds are indicted for a specific failure: they did not inquire of Yahweh. The flock scattered because leadership stopped asking (Jeremiah 10:21).
- The chapter closes in prayer, and the humility is startling: the way of man is not in himself. Correct me, but gently - not in anger, lest You reduce me to nothing (Jeremiah 10:23-24).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
Don't Learn the Way of the Nations	Jeremiah 10:2 • Leviticus 18:3 • Deuteronomy 18:9-14
The Idol Cut From a Tree	Jeremiah 10:3-4 • Isaiah 44:14-17 • Habakkuk 2:18-19
Idols That Cannot Speak or Walk	Jeremiah 10:5 • Psalm 115:4-8 • Isaiah 46:7
"There Is No One Like You"	Jeremiah 10:6-7 • Exodus 15:11 • Psalm 86:8-10
The Living God and Everlasting King	Jeremiah 10:10 • 1 Thessalonians 1:9 • 1 Timothy 1:17
Creation as Proof of Authority	Jeremiah 10:12 • Psalm 104:24 • Proverbs 3:19
Shepherds Who Did Not Inquire	Jeremiah 10:21 • Jeremiah 23:1-2 • Ezekiel 34:2-4
The Way of Man Is Not in Himself	Jeremiah 10:23 • Proverbs 16:9 • Proverbs 20:24

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
The One Through Whom All Things Were Made	Jeremiah 10:12 • Colossians 1:16-17 • John 1:3
All Nations Coming to Worship the King	Jeremiah 10:7 • Revelation 15:4 • Psalm 86:9
Turning From Idols to the Living God	Jeremiah 10:10 • 1 Thessalonians 1:9 • Acts 14:15
Chastening Received as a Son	Jeremiah 10:24 • Hebrews 12:5-6 • Psalm 6:1
The Shepherd Who Does Inquire	Jeremiah 10:21 • John 10:14-15 • Ezekiel 34:23
Steps Directed by Another Hand	Jeremiah 10:23 • Proverbs 16:9 • Philippians 2:13

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 10 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the idol-manufacture satire, the hymn to Yahweh's incomparability, and the closing prayer
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 10](#) - Torah-honoring treatment of "don't learn the way of the nations" and imported custom
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 10](#) - notes on the single Aramaic verse and the creation argument of verses 12-13

Jeremiah 10 - Opening Intro

There is a quiet joke running through the first half of this chapter, and it is worth catching. Yahweh describes idol-making as a construction project. Someone goes into the forest with an ax. Someone else does the plating. And then - this is the detail - they nail it down so it won't tip over.

A god that requires carpentry to remain upright. A god that has to be carried from place to place because it has feet that do not work.

And then the sentence that reframes the whole thing: don't be afraid of them. Not because fear is unreasonable, but because these particular objects are incapable in both directions. They cannot hurt you. They also cannot help you.

Set against that is verse 10 - true, living, everlasting - and verses 12 and 13, where the weather itself answers a voice.

But the chapter does not end in triumph. It ends with Jeremiah praying two of the most honest sentences a person can pray. I know I cannot direct my own steps. And: correct me, but go gently, because I will not survive the full measure.

Before we read, hold this: the difference between an idol and God is not that one is stronger. It is that one has to be carried, and the other carries.

Jeremiah 10:1-25 (WEB)

1 Hear the word which Yahweh speaks to you, house of Israel!

2 Yahweh says, "Don't learn the way of the nations, and don't be dismayed at the signs of the sky; for the nations are dismayed at them.

3 For the customs of the peoples are vanity; for one cuts a tree out of the forest, the work of the hands of the workman with the ax.

4 They deck it with silver and with gold. They fasten it with nails and with hammers, so that it can't move.¹

5 They are like a palm tree, of turned work, and don't speak. They must be carried, because they can't move. Don't be afraid of them; for they can't do evil, neither is it in them to do good."²

6 There is no one like you, Yahweh. You are great, and your name is great in might.

7 Who shouldn't fear you, King of the nations? For it belongs to you. Because among all the wise men of the nations, and in all their royal estate, there is no one like you.³

8 But they are together brutish and foolish, instructed by idols! It is just wood.

9 There is silver beaten into plates, which is brought from Tarshish, and gold from Uphaz, the work of the engraver and of the hands of the goldsmith. Their clothing is blue and purple. They are all the work of skillful men.

10 But Yahweh is the true God. He is the living God, and an everlasting King. At his wrath, the earth trembles. The nations aren't able to withstand his indignation.⁴

11 "You shall say this to them: 'The gods that have not made the heavens and the earth will perish from the earth, and from under the heavens.'"

12 God has made the earth by his power. He has established the world by his wisdom, and by his understanding has he stretched out the heavens.⁵

13 When he utters his voice, the waters in the heavens roar, and he causes the vapors to ascend from the ends of the earth. He makes lightnings for the rain, and brings the wind out of his treasuries.

¹ **Cross-Reference:** [Isaiah 44:14-17](#) • [Habakkuk 2:18-19](#) - the same satire - part of the tree warms the house, and part becomes the god it prays to

² **Cross-Reference:** [Psalm 115:4-8](#) - eyes that don't see and feet that don't walk - and makers who become like what they make

³ **Messianic Connection:** [Revelation 15:4](#) - who would not fear You - all nations coming to worship before the King

⁴ **Cross-Reference:** [Exodus 15:11](#) - who is like You among the gods, glorious in holiness, doing wonders

⁵ **Messianic Connection:** [Colossians 1:16-17](#) - all things created through Him and held together in Him

14 Every man has become brutish and without knowledge. Every goldsmith is disappointed by his engraved image; for his molten image is falsehood, and there is no breath in them.

15 They are vanity, a work of delusion. In the time of their visitation they will perish.

16 The portion of Jacob is not like these; for he is the maker of all things; and Israel is the tribe of his inheritance: Yahweh of Armies is his name.

17 Gather up your wares out of the land, you who live under siege.

18 For Yahweh says, "Behold, I will sling out the inhabitants of the land at this time, and will distress them, that they may feel it."

19 Woe is me because of my injury! My wound is serious; but I said, "Truly this is my grief, and I must bear it."

20 My tent has been destroyed, and all my cords are broken. My children have gone away from me, and they are no more. There is no one to spread my tent any more, to set up my curtains.

21 For the shepherds have become brutish, and have not inquired of Yahweh. Therefore they have not prospered, and all their flocks have scattered.⁶

22 The voice of news, behold, it comes, and a great commotion out of the north country, to make the cities of Judah a desolation, a dwelling place of jackals.

23 Yahweh, I know that the way of man is not in himself. It is not in man who walks to direct his steps.⁷

24 Yahweh, correct me, but gently; not in your anger, lest you reduce me to nothing.⁸

25 Pour out your wrath on the nations that don't know you, and on the families that don't call on your name; for they have devoured Jacob. Yes, they have devoured him, consumed him, and have laid waste his habitation.

⁶ Cross-Reference: [Ezekiel 34:2-4](#) - shepherds who fed themselves and left the flock unsought and unhealed

⁷ Cross-Reference: [Proverbs 16:9](#) - a man plans his course, but Yahweh directs the steps

⁸ Messianic Connection: [Hebrews 12:5-6](#) - the chastening of a father who disciplines every son He receives

CHAPTER 11 - The Covenant Read Aloud, and the Plot at Anathoth

Key Notes

- Jeremiah is sent to read the covenant terms publicly, beginning with the curse: cursed is the man who does not hear the words of this covenant (Jeremiah 11:1-3).
- The covenant is rooted in rescue - brought out of the iron furnace of Egypt - and its condition is a single verb: obey my voice. The relationship formula follows from it (Jeremiah 11:4).
- Jeremiah's own response is one word of assent - "Amen, Yahweh" - which places him under the same terms he is about to announce (Jeremiah 11:5).
- Yahweh's persistence is emphasized in the imagery of rising early: not a single warning but centuries of them, delivered each morning (Jeremiah 11:7).
- "A conspiracy is found" - the breach is not accidental drift but coordinated return to ancestral idolatry (Jeremiah 11:9-10).
- The arithmetic of idolatry is exposed: as many gods as there are cities, as many altars as there are streets in Jerusalem. Devotion measured by inventory (Jeremiah 11:13).
- The third prohibition on intercession, now with the added detail that they will cry out and the gods they chose will not answer (Jeremiah 11:11-14).
- The name Yahweh had given her - a green olive tree, beautiful with goodly fruit - is recalled at the moment fire is kindled on its branches (Jeremiah 11:16-17).
- The plot is revealed, and the language is unmistakable: like a gentle lamb led to the slaughter, unaware, while men planned to cut him off from the land of the living (Jeremiah 11:18-19).
- The plotters are the men of Anathoth - his own village, his own priestly family town - and their demand is that he stop prophesying in Yahweh's name (Jeremiah 11:21-23).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
Cursed Is the Man Who Does Not Hear	Jeremiah 11:3 • Deuteronomy 27:26 • Galatians 3:10
Brought Out of the Iron Furnace	Jeremiah 11:4 • Deuteronomy 4:20 • 1 Kings 8:51
Rising Early to Warn	Jeremiah 11:7 • Jeremiah 7:25 • 2 Chronicles 36:15
A Conspiracy Among the People	Jeremiah 11:9-10 • Ezekiel 22:25 • Hosea 6:9
Gods as Numerous as the Cities	Jeremiah 11:13 • Jeremiah 2:28 • Deuteronomy 32:16-17
"Don't Pray for This People"	Jeremiah 11:14 • Jeremiah 7:16 • Jeremiah 14:11
The Green Olive Tree	Jeremiah 11:16 • Psalm 52:8 • Romans 11:17-21
The One Who Tests Heart and Mind	Jeremiah 11:20 • Jeremiah 17:10 • 1 Chronicles 28:9

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
A Gentle Lamb Led to the Slaughter	Jeremiah 11:19 • Isaiah 53:7 • Acts 8:32
Rejected in His Own Hometown	Jeremiah 11:21 • Luke 4:24 • John 1:11
The Curse of the Law Borne by Another	Jeremiah 11:3 • Galatians 3:10 • Galatians 3:13
Branches Broken and Branches Grafted	Jeremiah 11:16 • Romans 11:17-21 • John 15:2
Committing the Cause to the Righteous Judge	Jeremiah 11:20 • 1 Peter 2:23 • Romans 12:19
Plots Devised Against the Messenger	Jeremiah 11:19 • Matthew 26:3-4 • John 11:53

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 11 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the covenant proclamation, the conspiracy, and the Anathoth plot against Jeremiah
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 11](#) - covenant-framed reading of the curse formula and the olive-tree image
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 11](#) - background on Anathoth and Jeremiah's priestly family connections

Jeremiah 11 - Opening Intro

Notice what Jeremiah says in verse 5. He has just been handed a message that begins with the word “cursed,” and he answers, “Amen, Yahweh.” He agrees with it. He does not negotiate the terms or ask for a softer version. He signs his name to the covenant he is about to preach - which means he is standing under it too.

That matters, because of what happens at the end of the chapter.

Verse 19 is one of the most quietly devastating verses in the prophets. “I was like a gentle lamb led to the slaughter. I didn’t know.” He had no idea. While he was faithfully carrying the message, people were sitting in rooms discussing how to end him.

And they were not strangers. Anathoth was his hometown - a priestly village a few miles from Jerusalem, full of people who had watched him grow up. Their condition was simple: stop speaking in that name, or die by our hand.

Before we read, sit with the cost. Obedience did not make Jeremiah safe at home. If anything, home was where it became most dangerous.

Jeremiah 11:1-23 (WEB)

- 1** The word that came to Jeremiah from Yahweh, saying,
- 2** “Hear the words of this covenant, and speak to the men of Judah, and to the inhabitants of Jerusalem;
- 3** and say to them, Yahweh, the God of Israel says: ‘Cursed is the man who doesn’t hear the words of this covenant,’^{9,10}
- 4** which I commanded your fathers in the day that I brought them out of the land of Egypt, out of the iron furnace,’ saying, ‘Obey my voice, and do them, according to all which I command you; so you shall be my people, and I will be your God;’¹¹
- 5** that I may establish the oath which I swore to your fathers, to give them a land flowing with milk and honey,’ as it is today.” Then answered I, and said, “Amen, Yahweh.”
- 6** Yahweh said to me, “Proclaim all these words in the cities of Judah, and in the streets of Jerusalem, saying, ‘Hear the words of this covenant, and do them.
- 7** For I earnestly protested to your fathers in the day that I brought them up out of the land of Egypt, even to this day, rising early and protesting, saying, “Obey my voice.”
- 8** Yet they didn’t obey, nor turn their ear, but everyone walked in the stubbornness of their evil heart. Therefore I brought on them all the words of this covenant, which I commanded them to do, but they didn’t do them.’”
- 9** Yahweh said to me, “A conspiracy is found among the men of Judah, and among the inhabitants of Jerusalem.
- 10** They have turned back to the iniquities of their forefathers, who refused to hear my words. They have gone after other gods to serve them. The house of Israel and the house of Judah have broken my covenant which I made with their fathers.
- 11** Therefore Yahweh says, ‘Behold, I will bring evil on them, which they will not be able to escape; and they will cry to me, but I will not listen to them.
- 12** Then the cities of Judah and the inhabitants of Jerusalem will go and cry to the gods to which they offer incense, but they will not save them at all in the time of their trouble.
- 13** For according to the number of your cities are your gods, Judah; and according to the number of the streets of Jerusalem have you set up altars to the shameful thing, even altars to burn incense to Baal.’

⁹ Cross-Reference: [Deuteronomy 27:26](#) - the closing curse of the covenant ceremony, answered by the people’s own Amen

¹⁰ Messianic Connection: [Galatians 3:10](#) - the curse of the law on all who do not continue in it - and the One who became that curse

¹¹ Cross-Reference: [Deuteronomy 4:20](#) - the iron furnace of Egypt, and a people taken out of it for an inheritance

14 “Therefore don’t pray for this people. Don’t lift up cry or prayer for them; for I will not hear them in the time that they cry to me because of their trouble.”¹²

15 What has my beloved to do in my house, since she has behaved lewdly with many, and the holy flesh has passed from you? When you do evil, then you rejoice.”

16 Yahweh called your name, “A green olive tree, beautiful with goodly fruit.” With the noise of a great roar he has kindled fire on it, and its branches are broken.”^{13,14}

17 For Yahweh of Armies, who planted you, has pronounced evil against you, because of the evil of the house of Israel and of the house of Judah, which they have done to themselves in provoking me to anger by offering incense to Baal.

18 Yahweh gave me knowledge of it, and I knew it. Then you showed me their doings.

19 But I was like a gentle lamb that is led to the slaughter. I didn’t know that they had devised plans against me, saying, “Let us destroy the tree with its fruit, and let us cut him off from the land of the living, that his name may be no more remembered.”^{15,16}

20 But, Yahweh of Armies, who judges righteously, who tests the heart and the mind, I will see your vengeance on them; for to you I have revealed my cause.”¹⁷

21 “Therefore Yahweh says concerning the men of Anathoth, who seek your life, saying, ‘You shall not prophesy in Yahweh’s name, that you not die by our hand;’¹⁸

22 therefore Yahweh of Armies says, ‘Behold, I will punish them. The young men will die by the sword. Their sons and their daughters will die by famine.

23 There will be no remnant to them, for I will bring evil on the men of Anathoth, even the year of their visitation.’”

¹² Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 7:16](#) - the same instruction given at the temple gate - intercession that will not be heard

¹³ Cross-Reference: [Psalm 52:8](#) - the green olive tree in God’s house, trusting in His loving kindness

¹⁴ Messianic Connection: [Romans 11:17-21](#) - natural branches broken off and a wild olive grafted in - with a warning against boasting

¹⁵ Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 11:20](#) • [Jeremiah 17:10](#) - the cause revealed to the One who tests the heart and the mind

¹⁶ Messianic Connection: [Isaiah 53:7](#) • [Acts 8:32](#) - the lamb led to slaughter who did not open His mouth

¹⁷ Messianic Connection: [1 Peter 2:23](#) - committing Himself to the One who judges righteously rather than threatening in return

¹⁸ Messianic Connection: [Luke 4:24](#) • [John 1:11](#) - no prophet accepted in his hometown; He came to His own and they did not receive Him

CHAPTER 12 - Why the Wicked Prosper, and a Question About Horses

Key Notes

- Jeremiah opens by conceding the verdict before he files the complaint: You are righteous, Yahweh - and then, having granted that, he says he would still like to argue the case (Jeremiah 12:1).
- The complaint is precise. Not merely that the wicked survive, but that they flourish: planted, rooted, growing, producing fruit. The imagery of blessing applied to the treacherous (Jeremiah 12:1-2).
- The sharpest line in the complaint: You are near in their mouth, and far from their heart. Their religion functions; it just doesn't reach anywhere (Jeremiah 12:2).
- He contrasts them with himself and appeals to inspection: You know me, You see me, You test my heart toward You (Jeremiah 12:3).
- Yahweh's answer explains nothing. It asks whether a man exhausted by footmen expects to race horses, and whether someone unsteady on level ground will manage the Jordan thickets (Jeremiah 12:5).
- Then the warning that lands hardest, given chapter 11: even your brothers and your father's house have dealt treacherously. Don't trust them, however beautifully they speak (Jeremiah 12:6).
- The tone shifts and it becomes clear that Yahweh is grieving too - I have forsaken my house, I have given the dearly beloved of my soul into the hand of her enemies (Jeremiah 12:7-8).
- "The whole land is made desolate, because no one cares." Indifference named as the engine of ruin (Jeremiah 12:10-11).
- The futility image: they sowed wheat and reaped thorns, exhausting themselves for nothing (Jeremiah 12:13).
- The chapter ends with a door left open for the nations themselves - plucked up, then possibly restored, and even built up among His people if they will learn to swear by His name (Jeremiah 12:14-17).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
Why Does the Way of the Wicked Prosper?	Jeremiah 12:1 • Job 21:7 • Psalm 73:3
Purer Eyes Than to See Evil	Jeremiah 12:1 • Habakkuk 1:13 • Psalm 10:1
Near in the Mouth, Far From the Heart	Jeremiah 12:2 • Isaiah 29:13 • Matthew 15:8
You Test My Heart Toward You	Jeremiah 12:3 • Psalm 139:23-24 • Jeremiah 17:10
Footmen and Horses	Jeremiah 12:5 • 1 Corinthians 10:13 • Hebrews 12:1-3
Betrayed by Your Father's House	Jeremiah 12:6 • Micah 7:5-6 • Psalm 55:12-14
Sown Wheat, Reaped Thorns	Jeremiah 12:13 • Haggai 1:6 • Micah 6:15

Topic	References
Compassion After the Plucking Up	Jeremiah 12:15 • Micah 7:18-19 • Deuteronomy 30:3

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
Lips Near and Hearts Far	Jeremiah 12:2 • Matthew 15:8 • Isaiah 29:13
Strength Given for the Harder Race	Jeremiah 12:5 • Hebrews 12:1-3 • Isaiah 40:31
Betrayed by Those Closest	Jeremiah 12:6 • Psalm 41:9 • John 13:18
The House Forsaken by Its Owner	Jeremiah 12:7 • Matthew 23:38 • Luke 13:34-35
The Nations Grafted In Among His People	Jeremiah 12:16 • Ephesians 2:12-13 • Isaiah 56:6-7
Compassion That Follows the Uprooting	Jeremiah 12:15 • Romans 11:23 • Micah 7:18-19

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 12 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the prophet's complaint, the footmen-and-horses reply, and the oracle to the neighboring nations
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 12](#) - reading of Yahweh's grief over His heritage and the conditional promise to the nations
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 12](#) - exposition of verse 5 and its place among Jeremiah's confessions

Jeremiah 12 - Opening Intro

This is the first of what are often called Jeremiah's confessions, and it is worth noting how he starts. He does not accuse God of injustice. He states the opposite - You are righteous - and then says he wants to argue anyway. That is not contradiction; it is faith arguing inside the relationship rather than walking out of it.

His question is the oldest one there is, and he asks it without decoration. Why do the wicked prosper? Not why are they tolerated - why do they thrive? Planted, rooted, fruitful. Every word he uses is a word for blessing.

And then Yahweh answers, and the answer is famously not an answer. If footmen wore you out, what will you do against cavalry? If you stumble on flat ground, how will you handle the thickets by the Jordan?

It sounds harsh until you notice what it assumes. Yahweh is not dismissing the question. He is telling Jeremiah that harder things are coming and that this conversation is preparation, not complaint resolution. The answer to “why is it hard” is “it will get harder, and I intend for you to be able to run.”

And then, so we do not mistake Yahweh for indifferent, verse 7 lets us hear His side of it. “The dearly beloved of my soul.” He is not describing an administrative decision.

Before we read, carry this honestly: sometimes the answer to our hardest question is not information. It is training.

Jeremiah 12:1-17 (WEB)

1 You are righteous, Yahweh, when I contend with you; yet I would like to reason the cause with you. Why does the way of the wicked prosper? Why are they all at ease who deal very treacherously?^{19,20}

2 You have planted them. Yes, they have taken root. They grow. Yes, they produce fruit. You are near in their mouth, and far from their heart.²¹

3 But you, Yahweh, know me. You see me, and test my heart toward you. Pull them out like sheep for the slaughter, and prepare them for the day of slaughter.²²

4 How long will the land mourn, and the herbs of the whole country wither? Because of the wickedness of those who dwell therein, the animals and birds are consumed; because they said, “He won’t see our latter end.”

5 “If you have run with the footmen, and they have wearied you, then how can you contend with horses? Though in a land of peace you are secure, yet how will you do in the pride of the Jordan?²³

6 For even your brothers, and the house of your father, even they have dealt treacherously with you! Even they have cried aloud after you! Don’t believe them, though they speak beautiful words to you.²⁴

7 “I have forsaken my house. I have cast off my heritage. I have given the dearly beloved of my soul into the hand of her enemies.²⁵

8 My heritage has become to me as a lion in the forest. She has uttered her voice against me. Therefore I have hated her.

¹⁹ **Cross-Reference:** [Job 21:7](#) • [Psalm 73:3](#) - the same question asked by Job and by Asaph - why the wicked grow old and mighty

²⁰ **Messianic Connection:** [Habakkuk 1:13](#) - purer eyes than to see evil, and yet apparent silence while the treacherous swallow the righteous

²¹ **Messianic Connection:** [Matthew 15:8](#) - a people honoring Him with their lips while their heart is far away

²² **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 17:10](#) - the One who searches the mind and tries the heart, giving according to each man’s ways

²³ **Messianic Connection:** [Hebrews 12:1-3](#) - laying aside every weight and running with endurance, considering Him who endured worse

²⁴ **Messianic Connection:** [John 13:18](#) - the one who shared His bread lifting up his heel against Him

²⁵ **Messianic Connection:** [Matthew 23:38](#) - your house left to you desolate - the owner departing His own dwelling

9 Is my heritage to me as a speckled bird of prey? Are the birds of prey against her all around? Go, assemble all the animals of the field. Bring them to devour.

10 Many shepherds have destroyed my vineyard. They have trodden my portion under foot. They have made my pleasant portion a desolate wilderness.

11 They have made it a desolation. It mourns to me, being desolate. The whole land is made desolate, because no one cares.

12 Destroyers have come on all the bare heights in the wilderness; for the sword of Yahweh devours from the one end of the land even to the other end of the land. No flesh has peace.

13 They have sown wheat, and have reaped thorns. They have exhausted themselves, and profit nothing. You will be ashamed of your fruits, because of Yahweh's fierce anger."

14 Yahweh says, "Concerning all my evil neighbors, who touch the inheritance which I have caused my people Israel to inherit: Behold, I will pluck them up from off their land, and will pluck up the house of Judah from among them.

15 It will happen, that after I have plucked them up, I will return and have compassion on them. I will bring them again, every man to his heritage, and every man to his land.²⁶

16 It will happen, if they will diligently learn the ways of my people, to swear by my name, 'As Yahweh lives;' even as they taught my people to swear by Baal; then will they be built up in the middle of my people.²⁷

17 But if they will not hear, then I will pluck up that nation, plucking up and destroying it," says Yahweh.

²⁶ **Cross-Reference:** [Micah 7:18-19](#) - the God who does not retain anger forever but returns to have compassion

²⁷ **Messianic Connection:** [Ephesians 2:12-13](#) - those once far off and without covenant brought near and built up among His people

Major Themes Across Jeremiah 10-12

- Gods that must be nailed upright and carried, set beside the God whose voice moves the weather
- Idols as powerless in both directions - unable to harm, and equally unable to help
- The living God, the true God, the everlasting King - three titles no manufactured thing can hold
- Leadership that stopped inquiring, and a flock scattered as the direct result
- The humblest prayer in the book: I cannot direct my own steps; correct me, but gently
- A covenant read aloud with its curse intact, and a prophet who says Amen to terms that bind him too
- Devotion counted by inventory - a god for every city, an altar for every street
- The gentle lamb who did not know, and the hometown that wanted him silenced
- A complaint filed inside the relationship: You are righteous, and I still want to argue
- An answer that is training rather than explanation - footmen now, horses ahead
- Yahweh's own grief named plainly: the dearly beloved of My soul, handed over
- A door left open even for the nations who plundered, if they will learn to swear by His name

Benediction

Let this be the word that goes before us tonight:

May the God who needs no nails to hold Him up expose every carried thing we have been calling a god, and may we set down what we have been hauling.

May He deliver us from importing the fears of the nations, and may we learn to be undismayed by signs that terrify everyone around us.

May our leaders inquire of Him before they act, and may we not scatter for lack of someone willing to ask.

May we pray Jeremiah's prayer honestly - that we cannot direct our own steps, and that we need correction measured out gently, because we would not survive the full weight of it.

May we say Amen to the covenant even where it binds us, and may our obedience not depend on being welcome at home.

May He make us able to bring our hardest questions to Him without leaving the room, and may we receive training when we asked for an explanation.

May we run with the horses when the footmen are behind us, strengthened by the One who endured worse and did not grow weary.

And may every promise He has spoken over us stand up, come forth, and manifest in its appointed time.

Amen.